

Psalms 147

Praise Is Good and Pleasant

Praise ye the Lord: for it is good to sing praises unto our God; for it is pleasant, and praise is comely

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Praise ye the LORD: for it is good to sing praises unto our God; for it is pleasant; and praise is comely.
- 2 The LORD doth build up Jerusalem: he gathereth together the outcasts of Israel.
- 3 He healeth the broken in heart, and bindeth up their wounds.
- 4 He telleth the number of the stars; he calleth them all by their names.
- 5 Great is our Lord, and of great power: his understanding is infinite.
- 6 The LORD lifteth up the meek: he casteth the wicked down to the ground.
- 7 Sing unto the LORD with thanksgiving; sing praise upon the harp unto our God:
- 8 Who covereth the heaven with clouds, who prepareth rain for the earth, who maketh grass to grow upon the mountains.
- 9 He giveth to the beast his food, and to the young ravens which cry.
- 10 He delighteth not in the strength of the horse: he taketh not pleasure in the legs of a man.
- 11 The LORD taketh pleasure in them that fear him, in those that hope in his mercy.
- 12 Praise the LORD, O Jerusalem; praise thy God, O Zion.
- 13 For he hath strengthened the bars of thy gates; he hath blessed thy children within thee.
- 14 He maketh peace in thy borders, and filleth thee with the finest of the wheat.
- 15 He sendeth forth his commandment upon earth: his word runneth very swiftly.
- 16 He giveth snow like wool: he scattereth the hoar frost like ashes.
- 17 He casteth forth his ice like morsels: who can stand before his cold?
- 18 He sendeth out his word, and melteth them: he causeth his wind to blow, and the waters flow.
- 19 He sheweth his word unto Jacob, his statutes and his judgments unto Israel.
- 20 He hath not dealt so with any nation: and as for his judgments, they have not known them. Praise ye the LORD.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 147 weaves together God's tender restoration of Jerusalem, His vast cosmic knowledge of the stars, His provision for animals and crops, and His specific covenant revelation to Israel—arguing throughout that the same God who names every star also heals the brokenhearted and feeds the young ravens. Henry highlights the psalm's deliberate juxtaposition of the immense and the intimate, refusing to let cosmic scale crowd out personal tenderness.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

Praise is commended as good, pleasant, and fitting, immediately grounded in specific action: God builds up Jerusalem, gathers the outcasts of Israel, heals the brokenhearted, and binds up their wounds—restoration described in deeply personal, almost medical terms.

Verse 4-6

Cosmic knowledge follows: God counts the number of the stars and calls each one by name—a picture of intimate, individualized attention applied to the vastness of the universe. That same power lifts up the humble while casting the wicked down to the ground.

Verse 7-9

The call to sing with thanksgiving and praise with the harp is followed by pictures of provision for creation itself: God covers the sky with clouds, prepares rain for the earth, makes grass grow on the mountains, and gives food to cattle and to the young ravens when they cry.

Verse 10-11

A pointed contrast follows: God takes no delight in the strength of a horse or the speed of human legs; His pleasure is in those who fear Him and hope in His mercy—strength and speed dismissed as impressive but ultimately beside the point.

Verse 12-14

Jerusalem and Zion are called to praise specifically because God strengthens the bars of her gates, blesses her children within, establishes peace in her borders, and satisfies her with the finest wheat—security and abundance named together.

Verse 15-18

God's command is described as swift and effective even over the weather: He sends snow like wool, scatters frost like ashes, casts down hail like crumbs, and no one can stand before His cold—yet He sends His word again and it melts, causing wind to blow and waters to flow. Creation obeys instantly at His word.

Verse 19-20

The psalm closes by naming God's greatest gift to Israel specifically: He has shown His word to Jacob, His statutes and judgments to Israel, and has not dealt this way with any other nation, who do not know His judgments—revelation itself treated as the psalm's climactic evidence of favor, closing with praise to the Lord.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

The same God who names every star and commands the weather with a word is shown, in the same breath, tending personally to the brokenhearted, the humble, and even the cries of young ravens—cosmic power and intimate tenderness are not in tension but united. The psalm's climax is not a display of might but the gift of revealed truth, suggesting that knowing God's word is the deepest favor a people can receive.

Application for life today.

Let the psalm's juxtaposition of the cosmic and the intimate—God naming stars and healing the brokenhearted in the same passage—reassure you that your own small griefs are not too minor for His attention. Notice verse 10's dismissal of strength and speed as the basis of God's delight, and consider whether you are pursuing impressiveness rather than the humble hope He actually values. Treat your access to God's revealed word, as verses 19–20 do, as a distinct gift worth active gratitude, not something to take for granted.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. How does the psalm's pairing of God naming every star (v. 4) with healing the brokenhearted (v. 3) speak to whether your own struggles feel 'too small' for His attention?

2. Where might you be chasing strength or speed—verse 10's 'strength of the horse' or 'legs of a man'—rather than the humble hope God actually delights in?

3. How does treating your access to Scripture, as verses 19–20 describe Israel's unique gift, change your sense of gratitude for something you might otherwise take for granted?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).